

Growing Gratitude and Confidence

A Caring Classroom Philosophy for Building Confidence, Kindness, and Community



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Being Grateful for What Makes You Special: Caring Classroom Philosophy

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www.ridersmagicmark.com

Rider's Magic Mark



SCAN ME!

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*****This curriculum includes alignment to the National Association for the Education of Young Children (NAEYC) and the Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning (CASEL). Because professional standards and frameworks may be revised over time, educators are encouraged to review the most current versions of these frameworks to ensure continued alignment with current guidance.

Background Information

Helping Children Discover Their Unique Strengths, Build Confidence, and Celebrate What Makes Them Special

A Note to Families and Educators:

This curriculum is designed to be used in conjunction with *Rider's Magic Mark* by Dr. Tisha Shipley.



This engaging two-week social-emotional learning curriculum was created to accompany the book *Rider's Magic Mark* and is meant to provide meaningful opportunities for children to explore what makes them unique while also developing gratitude, empathy, self-confidence, and positive relationships.

Rider's Magic Mark offers rich opportunities for vocabulary development, story comprehension, and character understanding. It also provides shared language and emotional connections that support gratitude and self-awareness concepts explored throughout this curriculum.

When the story and lessons are experienced together, children are better able to make meaningful connections, participate in deeper conversations, and develop a stronger understanding of gratitude, identity, and the qualities that make them unique.

This integrated approach supports social-emotional learning by reinforcing key themes through storytelling, discussion, reflection, and hands-on classroom experiences.

More than ever, in today's world, children need to know their worth. By taking the time to read this curriculum, you are already demonstrating your commitment to supporting children's emotional well-being. Together, we can create meaningful changes that nurture confidence, connection, kindness, and lifelong mental wellness in children.

The Why

Teaching children gratitude is about much more than simply saying “thank you.” Gratitude helps children develop a healthy self-concept, emotional resilience, empathy, and positive relationships with others. When children learn to recognize the good in themselves and the world around them, they begin to build confidence, kindness, and a stronger sense of belonging.



Incorporating gratitude into daily life or classroom practices does not have to feel overwhelming. Starting small and choosing one or two meaningful activities to practice regularly with children can make a lasting impact. These simple experiences

enrich childhood while helping children develop habits and perspectives that support lifelong emotional well-being.

Teaching and learning about gratitude is a journey, and it is never too late to begin. Research and guidance in child development and social-emotional learning suggest that fostering a mindset of appreciation can help nurture happier, more compassionate, and resilient individuals. Portions of this philosophy were informed by resources provided by Children’s Nebraska.

Research in early childhood education and social-emotional learning (SEL) suggests that children who regularly practice gratitude often demonstrate stronger emotional regulation, improved peer relationships, increased empathy, and a more positive outlook when facing challenges. These experiences help create classroom communities where children feel safe, valued, capable, and connected.

One of the most powerful ways children develop self-worth is through the words and encouragement of trusted adults. A child’s self-concept begins forming very early in life, and the affirming messages shared by parents, caregivers, and teachers often become the inner voice children carry with them as they grow.

The games, activities, affirmations, and SEL lessons included in this curriculum are intentionally designed because young children learn best through play, repetition, meaningful relationships, and hands-on experiences. When children practice noticing joyful moments, appreciating others, and speaking kindly to themselves, they strengthen emotional skills that support lifelong mental wellness.

Gratitude activities also encourage children to slow down, reflect, and focus on positive experiences, helping increase feelings of connection, emotional safety, and joy within both classroom and home communities.

The following activities and lessons are designed to support both classroom and home environments. Adapt them to fit your family’s or classroom’s unique routines and lifestyle. Encourage children to talk, learn, play, and explore what makes them special and what they are grateful for. Along the way, you may even discover something meaningful about yourself as well.

When children experience gratitude practice consistently at both school and home, they are more likely to develop lasting habits of empathy, self-awareness, kindness, and emotional resilience.

For Educators

Gratitude helps build a strong classroom community by creating an environment where children feel valued, connected, safe, and supported. When children learn to recognize kindness in themselves and others, they begin to develop empathy, respect, and a greater sense of belonging within the group.



Practicing gratitude encourages children to notice positive actions, celebrate one another's strengths, and build meaningful relationships with peers and adults. As children share kind words, express appreciation, and participate in collaborative activities, they learn that every member of the classroom community is important and has something special to contribute.

Gratitude-based activities also help strengthen communication, cooperation, and emotional understanding. Over time, these experiences help create a classroom culture rooted in kindness, encouragement, inclusion, and mutual respect. When children feel emotionally safe and appreciated, they are often more confident, engaged, and willing to take positive social and academic risks.

A caring classroom community begins when children understand that they are seen, heard, valued, and appreciated for who they are.

You will find the alignment to standards at the end of this packet.

You will find extension activities on the website to further your study to incorporate the learning throughout the year.

For Families

Gratitude can also help strengthen family relationships and create a more connected home environment. When families practice gratitude together, children learn to recognize acts of kindness, appreciate everyday moments, and value the people around them.



Simple conversations about what family members are grateful for can encourage communication, emotional connection, and empathy. These moments help children feel seen, heard, loved, and important within their family community. Practicing gratitude at home can also help children develop positive thinking skills, emotional resilience, and a greater appreciation for both themselves and others.

As children begin to notice the good in their lives, they often become more thoughtful, caring, and confident. Gratitude activities can create meaningful family traditions while helping build a home environment rooted in kindness, encouragement, respect, and love.

Most importantly, children learn gratitude best by watching the adults around them. When families model appreciation, compassion, encouragement, and positive self-talk, children begin carrying those same habits into their relationships, school experiences, and everyday lives.

The How

The following curriculum is organized into a two-week format designed to help children build gratitude, confidence, kindness, self-awareness, and positive classroom connections.

This curriculum is intentionally flexible and can be implemented in any way that best supports your students and classroom routines. Activities and lessons may be used during morning meeting, circle time, centers, large group instruction, transitions, after lunch, recess reflection, end-of-day closing routines, or whenever it feels most appropriate throughout your day.

You know your students, classroom community, and schedule best. Feel free to adapt, modify, shorten, extend, or differentiate activities to meet the developmental, emotional, and academic needs of the children you teach.



The goal of this curriculum is not perfection or rigid implementation. The purpose is to naturally embed gratitude, kindness, confidence, and social-emotional learning into the meaningful moments that already happen within your classroom each day.

At the end of the two weeks, the hope is to continue integrating many of these practices into your daily classroom routine throughout the school year.

Author's Side Note

My mother always told me I was the best at whatever I was doing and that I was going to be the prettiest girl at the party. My self-concept and self-awareness began with her words. Children need to hear loving, affirming messages from the people who care about them most. The way adults speak to children often becomes the way children eventually speak to themselves.

When we intentionally teach gratitude, confidence, kindness, and self-love, we help children build a strong emotional foundation that can support them throughout their lives.

******Before you begin: Read aloud Rider's Magic Mark and complete the companion series.***

By Dr. Tisha Shipley

Curriculum Introduction

The next two weeks will be filled with opportunities for growth, connection, reflection, creativity, and excitement as children explore gratitude, kindness, self-awareness, and what makes them special.

Each day of this curriculum provides examples of activities, conversations, classroom practices, and discussion prompts that can be adapted to fit the unique needs of your students and classroom community. The scripts and lessons are designed to help you get started, but they are meant to be flexible. Use the parts that work best for you and your students, and feel free to modify activities, questions, and routines in ways that feel meaningful and developmentally appropriate for your classroom.

This curriculum is centered around you, your students, and the classroom community you build together each day.

Because children learn and grow differently across age groups and developmental levels, many activities may need to be differentiated or adjusted. Some students may enjoy drawing and sharing verbally, while others may prefer movement, play-based learning, sensory experiences, or small group conversations. The activities are flexible and can easily be expanded, simplified, shortened, or adapted to meet the needs of your learners.

Most importantly, this curriculum is designed to help children feel seen, valued, connected, and appreciated for who they are. Through gratitude practices, meaningful conversations, affirmations, and playful experiences, children begin building emotional skills that support confidence, empathy, kindness, resilience, and positive relationships with others.

Prep for week 1:



Materials Needed

- Book: *Rider's Magic Mark*
- Classroom bulletin board for ongoing displays
- Construction paper (hearts and star shapes large enough for students to draw or write on)
- Gratitude jar or gratitude box
- Classroom mirrors (large and/or handheld for student use)
- Gratitude bag (optional: sent home or brought from home)
- Student notebook or journal
- Optional: printable journal on Rider's Magic Mark website
- Optional: large butcher paper for group poem writing

 Weekly Implementation Guide

Week 1

Monday-What Does It Mean to Be Grateful?

- Classroom Discussion and Questions
 - Introduce the “Gratitude Bulletin Board”
This will serve as a living classroom display where students add drawings, words, or reflections throughout the week.
 - Send home the Family Letter today explaining the curriculum
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Tuesday-What Makes you Special?

- Begin daily welcome and exit routines
(Morning greetings and end-of-day goodbyes to build connection and classroom community)
 - Read *Rider’s Magic Mark*
 - Discussion prompt
 - Extension activity:
“I Am Special and Unique Because...”
Students add responses to the Gratitude Bulletin Board
 - Movement and SEL Activity: “Find Someone Who...”
-

Wednesday-Celebrating What Makes Us Unique

- Introduce the Gratitude Journal—First Journal Prompt
 - Gratitude circle time activity and Reflection Questions
 - Send home the Gratitude Bag letter. Bag is due on Monday of next week. Remind children.
-

Thursday-Affirmations: Speaking Kind Words to Ourselves

- Classroom Discussion
- Mirror Talk: Introduce classroom mirror hung at children’s eye level (large mirror recommended) Optional: provide handheld mirrors for students
- Classroom affirmation practice
- Optional video included: “Positive Affirmations for Kids” (YouTube video)
 - These activities will be used for affirmations, self-reflection, and confidence-building.

Friday-What Makes Me Special and What am I Grateful For?

- Introduce the Gratitude Jar or Box
Explain how students can add written or drawn notes of gratitude throughout the coming days or weeks
- Mini extension: Community Gratitude journal practice
- Gratitude Classroom Poem
- Send home Gratitude Celebration letter. This celebration will take place the following Friday. (Gratitude Bag reminder is included in the letter.)
 - Remind children their “My Gratitude and Special Things Bag” is due on Monday

Prep for week 2



Materials Needed

- Ball of yarn (for classroom community connection activity)
- Large butcher paper (for life-size student outlines)
- Markers, crayons, paint, or coloring materials
- Craft materials for adding hair, eyes, clothing, and other personal features
- Journals or writing paper
- Gratitude jar
- Music device and playlist of your choice
- Mirrors (large classroom mirror and optional handheld mirrors)
- Optional: “Positive Affirmations for Kids” YouTube video
- Room arrangement and decorations for Family Celebration



Weekly Implementation Guide

Week 2

Monday – Gratitude in Action

- Remind students about the Gratitude Jar
 - Classroom Community Web Activity using yarn and discussion
 - Gratitude Journal reflection and Discussion Connection
 - Introduce Home Extension Activity: Gratitude & Specials Bag presentation
-

Tuesday – Connection Through Kindness

- Classroom Community “Me Too” Game
 - Gratitude Jar reminder
 - Gratitude Journal prompt choices
 - Optional Journal Return Sharing Activity: Special Person
-

Wednesday – Celebrating What Makes Us Unique

- Life-Size Gratitude & “Special Me” Activity
 - Students decorate life-size outlines with personal features, interests, and strengths
 - Classroom discussion about individuality, gratitude, and self-confidence: Sharing and Caring
-

Thursday – Compliments and Reflection

- Compliment Circle
 - Journal – “What Makes Me Special”
 - Family Celebration Reminder
-

Friday-Celebrate What Makes Us Unique

- Overview of the last 2 weeks (Gratitude Unit)
- Gratitude Dance Break
- Optional Ideas for Your Gratitude Celebration
- Teacher Self-Reflection

Week 1: Monday

What Does It Mean to Be Grateful?

Teacher Note

Keep discussions natural, supportive, and student led. The goal is participation, connection, and building a positive classroom community where all students feel seen, valued, and included.

Lesson Purpose

This lesson introduces children to the concept of gratitude by helping them recognize the people, experiences, and personal qualities that bring meaning and joy to their lives. Through discussion, reflection, and classroom community-building activities, children begin developing self-awareness, appreciation for others, and a sense of belonging.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, children will be able to:

- ✓ Explain what it means to be grateful.
 - ✓ Identify something they appreciate about their lives or themselves.
 - ✓ Recognize that each person has unique qualities that make them special.
 - ✓ Participate in building a classroom gratitude community.
-

Teacher Script

“Good morning, friends! Today we are going to talk about being grateful.

Does anyone know what the word grateful means? (Allow children to think out loud.)

Being grateful means noticing the good things in our lives and feeling thankful for them. Sometimes we are grateful for big things like our families and friends, and sometimes we are grateful for little things like a sunny day, a favorite toy, or a hug from our favorite person.

Being grateful also means appreciating the things that make you special. Maybe you are a kind friend, a great helper, a creative artist, or someone who makes others smile. We can even be grateful for the things we see on the outside that make us unique, like freckles, curly hair, glasses, dimples, or birthmarks. Like In Rider’s Magic Mark those friends were thankful grateful for their mark when they found them.

Every person is different, and that is what makes our classroom so wonderful.

When we practice gratitude, our hearts grow happier and kinder. We begin to notice more joy around us and learn to appreciate ourselves and others.”

Discuss With Students

Being grateful helps us notice the good things in our lives. When we practice gratitude, we learn to appreciate the people, experiences, and special qualities that help us feel happy, loved, and connected.

Gratitude Can Help Us:

- Feel happier and calmer
- Show kindness to others
- Take care of the things we have
- Notice the good even on hard days
- Feel proud of who we are
- Help others feel important and appreciated

“When we say ‘thank you,’ share kind words, or think about something good in our day, our hearts grow bigger with kindness and joy. Gratitude reminds us that even small things — a smile, a hug, a friend, or a sunny day — can be very special.

Being grateful also helps us remember that everyone has something wonderful about them, including YOU!”

Class Discussion Prompt

“Today, I want you to think about things you are grateful for. Can anyone think of something right off the top of their head?”

(Teacher models first by sharing a personal example.)

Allow students time to share responses. Encourage excitement, discussion, and participation from all learners. You may also show an object or picture of something you are grateful for to support engagement and understanding.

Gratitude Wall Introduction

Introduce the Gratitude Wall and explain:

“This is a special space in our classroom where we will add things we are grateful for throughout our learning.”

Teacher Note:

Create a bulletin board titled **“We Are Grateful For...”** ****Post your own gratitude note before you introduce this project to your students. Read it aloud.**

Students will add:

- Sticky notes
- Drawings
- Photographs
- Written ideas

This can become a permanent classroom feature that grows throughout the year.



Closing Reflection Question (you can have children add this to the gratitude wall if you choose)

Ask students at the end of the day:

“What is one thing about YOU that you are grateful for today?”

Students may respond with:

- A feeling
 - A talent or skill
 - Something their body can do
 - Something that makes them unique and special
-



Family Extension: Home and School Connection

Encourage families to continue conversations at home:

- What made you happy today?
- What are you thankful for?
- What makes you special?
- How did you show kindness today?

Family Ideas:

- Share gratitude at dinner
- Write kind notes
- Create a gratitude jar
- Talk about strengths and talents

These small moments build confidence, connection, and self-worth.

Home Letter to Families

This letter is sent home to introduce families to the gratitude curriculum and to invite them into the learning process. It helps build a strong home-school connection by explaining what students are learning in the classroom and providing simple conversation prompts and extension activities families can use at home to support gratitude, kindness, and self-awareness.

Sample Letter to Families

Dear Families,

Over the next few weeks, our classroom community will be exploring what it means to be grateful and discovering the unique qualities that make each of us special in the world.

Through stories, discussions, activities, and classroom conversations, children will practice recognizing moments of thankfulness, expressing appreciation for others, and building confidence in who they are. Our goal is to help students develop empathy, kindness, self-awareness, and positive relationships while understanding that everyone has something meaningful to contribute to the world around them.

We invite you to continue these conversations at home by asking your child:

- What made you smile today?
- What is something you are thankful for?
- What makes you special?
- What is something kind or helpful you did today?
- What is something you are proud of about yourself?

As a family extension activity, we encourage you to create a simple “Gratitude Moment” together each day. This could include:

- Sharing one thing you are thankful for at dinner

- Writing kind notes to one another
- Talking about something positive before bedtime

You might also help your child notice their own strengths by celebrating acts of kindness, creativity, bravery, curiosity, or perseverance.

Thank you for partnering with us as we help children grow socially, emotionally, and academically. We look forward to sharing this meaningful learning journey with your child.

Warmly,
[Your Name]

Resource for Adults, Educators, and Families

For additional information about gratitude and classroom community building, visit:

[Education World – Practicing Gratitude Personally and Professionally in the Classroom Community](#)

Week 1 – Tuesday

What Makes You Special?

Teacher Reminder

- Some students may struggle to identify strengths
- Some students may not hear affirming language at home
- Keep all SEL experiences safe, supportive, and pressure-free
- Focus on belonging, acceptance, and emotional safety

Your words may become part of a child's inner voice.

Lesson Purpose

This lesson helps children develop a positive sense of identity by recognizing and appreciating the qualities, strengths, talents, and characteristics that make them unique. Through the read-aloud *Rider's Magic Mark*, classroom discussion, reflection, and movement activities, children explore the importance of self-acceptance, belonging, and celebrating differences in themselves and others.

Children learn that gratitude is not only about appreciating people and experiences but also about recognizing the special qualities they bring to the world.

Learning Objectives

Children will be able to:

- Explain that every person has unique qualities, strengths, and characteristics that make them special.
 - Identify personal qualities, talents, abilities, or physical characteristics they appreciate about themselves.
 - Recognize and celebrate similarities and differences among classmates.
 - Practice using positive language to describe themselves and others.
 - Demonstrate respect, kindness, and appreciation for individual differences.
-

New Practice:



Daily Classroom Routine: Morning and Exit Practices

Begin your new daily classroom practice: a welcome and exit routine. This will reinforce yesterday's discussion on gratitude.

Morning Welcome Routine

Each morning, stand at your classroom door and personally greet every child. Make eye contact, use their name, shake their hand, and say:

- “Good morning, Miss ____.”
- “Good morning, Mr. ____.”

Encourage students to greet you in return.

Take a moment to build connection with each child by sharing a positive message such as:

- “I love how you always come into our classroom with a smile.”
- “You are such a thoughtful helper.”
- “I can tell you are ready for a great day today.”
- “I am grateful for you today.”

You may also invite students to share something they are grateful for as they enter.

These intentional morning interactions help children feel seen, valued, safe, and connected. Over time, this routine strengthens relationships, communication skills, emotional security, and classroom belonging.

End-of-Day Exit Routine

At the end of the day, allow students to say goodbye in a way that feels comfortable to them:

- High five
- Handshake (hand hug)
- Fist bump
- Hug (if appropriate)
- Wave or smile

Providing choice supports:

- Emotional safety
- Body autonomy
- Communication skills
- Respect for personal boundaries

A consistent goodbye routine helps children transition home feeling calm, acknowledged, and connected.

Although simple, these daily routines help build a classroom culture rooted in gratitude, respect, kindness, and belonging.

Teacher Script

“Good morning, friends!

Yesterday we talked about what it means to be grateful. Being grateful means noticing the good things in our lives and feeling thankful for them. We can be grateful for people we love, things that help us, fun experiences, and even special things about ourselves.

When we practice gratitude, we help our hearts grow happier and kinder. We learn to appreciate ourselves, our friends, and the world around us.

Do you know what I am grateful for? I am grateful for YOU and our classroom community. I am grateful because every single one of you is different, and that is what makes you so special.”

Read Aloud

Rider's Magic Mark
By Dr. Tisha Shipley

Discussion: What Makes You Special?

This is the second time we have read this story. And in the story, we learned that every person has something special about them. Some people are kind helpers, some are creative thinkers, some make others laugh, and some never give up when things are hard.

Some special qualities can be seen on the outside, and some are on the inside.

Being grateful means noticing the good things in our lives, including the wonderful things about ourselves.

Discussion Prompts

Invite students to respond and participate. What is something that makes you unique? Let's talk about the things we can see with our eyes that make us special. (Example questions):

- Does anyone have freckles?
- Who wears glasses?
- Does anyone have curly hair?
- Who has a unique smile?
- Does anyone have a birthmark or beauty mark?
- Who has straight hair?
- Who has long hair or short hair?
- What is something you notice about your eyes, hair, or face that is special to you?
- Does anyone have a feature that looks like someone in their family?
- What is something about your appearance that makes you feel proud or happy?

Invite students to respond and participate. Let's talk about the things inside of us that make us special.

- Who is brave or courageous?
- What is something kind you do for others?
- What is something you are good at?
- What is something that makes you a good friend?

Teacher:

"Being grateful for yourself means knowing there is no one else exactly like you, and that is what makes you special."

"When we learn to appreciate the things that make us different, both inside and outside, we can feel proud of who we are. We can also learn to celebrate the unique qualities in others."

Being grateful for yourself means recognizing that there is no one else exactly like you, and that is something truly special".

Extension Activity: "I Am Special and Unique Because..."

Create a classroom display by adding to your Gratitude Wall.

Give students a heart or star and invite them to complete sentence starters:

- I am special because...
- I feel proud when...

- I help others by...
- One thing I love about myself is...
- I am thankful for my ability to...

Students may:

- Draw
- Write
- Dictate responses
- Share with a partner or teacher

Display responses to build a visual celebration of identity and belonging.



Movement and SEL Activity: “Find Someone Who...” You can put this to music if you choose.

Students move around the room to find classmates who:

- Wear glasses
- Share a favorite color
- Are kind helpers
- Are good listeners
- Enjoy drawing
- Love animals
- Make others laugh

Students share and notice similarities and differences, building connection and appreciation.

Week 1 – Wednesday

Celebrating What Makes Us Unique

Teacher Reminder

- Some students may need support identifying their strengths
- Model positive and affirming language throughout the day
- Celebrate effort, kindness, creativity, bravery, and growth
- Keep all discussions emotionally safe and encouraging

Remember: children often internalize the language they hear most often from trusted adults.

Lesson Purpose

This lesson supports children in developing self-awareness and confidence by helping them identify and celebrate their unique strengths, talents, characteristics, and experiences. Through reflection, journaling, discussion, and family connection, children learn that gratitude includes appreciating who they are and recognizing the positive qualities they bring to their classroom community.

Children are encouraged to develop a positive self-image while learning that every person has something valuable and special to contribute.

Learning Objectives

Children will be able to:

- Identify personal strengths, talents, interests, and qualities they appreciate about themselves.
 - Express gratitude for personal characteristics, abilities, and experiences.
 - Use positive language to describe themselves and others.
 - Reflect on feelings, experiences, and moments that bring happiness and pride.
 - Communicate personal ideas through speaking, drawing, writing, or other forms of expression.
 - Recognize that each person contributes unique qualities to a classroom community.
-

Teacher Script

“Good morning, friends!

Yesterday we talked about being grateful for the things that make us different and special.

We learned that everyone is unique in their own way. Some things that make us special are on the inside like being kind, brave, helpful, caring, or creative. Some things that make us special can also be seen on the outside like freckles, curly hair, glasses, dimples, birthmarks, different skin tones, or even the way we smile”. (You can have children stand, raise their hand etc.).

(Teacher may choose to show photographs or visuals that represent diversity and uniqueness.)

“We also created our ‘Special and Unique’ classroom wall yesterday. Do you remember what you shared about yourself? What are you grateful for? What makes you special?”

Allow time for student reflection, sharing, and celebration of ideas. You could let them “share and tell” from the gratitude wall.

 **Introduce students to their Gratitude Journal**, a special place where they can draw, write, and reflect each day.

This journal will become a daily practice throughout the curriculum. It is designed to help children collect their thoughts, notice moments of gratitude, and express what makes them feel happy, proud, and special.

Students may:

- draw pictures
- write words or sentences
- dictate ideas to a teacher
- or combine writing and drawing

The purpose of the journal is to give children a consistent space to reflect on their learning, emotions, and experiences over time. As the year continues, they will be able to look back and see their growth, self-awareness, and understanding of gratitude deepen.

This practice supports:

- reflection skills
- emotional awareness
- confidence and self-expression

- writing and language development
- mindfulness and gratitude habits

Encourage students to use their journal as a personal space where all ideas are valued and celebrated.

Gratitude Journal Prompt

“One thing that makes me special is...”

Students may include:

- talents
 - personality traits
 - physical features
 - interests
 - ways they help others
-

Circle Time Activity

Sit in a circle and invite students to complete:

- “Today I feel grateful for...”
- “Something special about me is...”

This builds listening skills, empathy, communication, and confidence while strengthening peer connections.

Gratitude Reflection Questions

Use these questions during whole group, partner talk, journaling, or small group discussion:

- What is something special about you?
- What is a talent or strength you are thankful for?
- How do your special qualities help others?
- What makes your heart happy?
- Who helped you discover something special about yourself?
- What makes your family or friends grateful for you?

- What is something only you can bring to the world?
-

Home Extension Activity

“My Gratitude and Special Things Bag”

Explain to children what they will need to do.

Today, you will either take home a special Gratitude Bag or bring one from home. This bag will help us celebrate what makes you unique and special.

Inside your Gratitude Bag, you will include a few special items that tell us more about you.

Send home or provide a small bag for students to collect:

- 3 things they are grateful for
- 3 things they are proud of that make them special

Items may include:

- drawings
- photographs
- small objects
- written notes
- meaningful personal items

Students may share their bags with the class when comfortable.

This activity strengthens:

- gratitude
- reflection
- communication
- self-confidence
- family connection

You can share a sample bag if you would like, or show things that someone may include in a bag.

Sample Letter to Families

Dear Families,

As part of our learning about gratitude, kindness, and celebrating what makes each child unique, we are inviting your child to participate in a special home extension activity.

Please help your child find or bring a small bag from home. Together, encourage your child to collect:

- 3 things they are grateful for
- 3 things they are proud of that make them special

These items may include small objects, drawings, photographs, notes, or meaningful treasures connected to their life experiences.

This activity encourages children to reflect, share, and celebrate who they are while building gratitude and confidence. We encourage you to talk with your child about why each item is meaningful, as these conversations strengthen connection at home.

Children will have the opportunity to share their bags with the classroom community on:

Please return the bag by:

Thank you for supporting this meaningful learning experience and helping us build a classroom community rooted in gratitude, kindness, and belonging.

Week 1 – Thursday

Affirmations: Speaking Kind Words to Ourselves

Teacher Reminder

- Some children may feel shy saying affirmations at first
- Participation can be optional, whispered, or done with a partner
- Model affirmations consistently so children feel safe joining in
- Focus on effort and participation, not perfection

Affirmations become powerful when they are repeated in a safe, supportive, and joyful environment.

Lesson Purpose

This lesson introduces children to the practice of using affirmations and positive self-talk as a way to build confidence, self-awareness, and emotional well-being. Children learn that the words they say to themselves can influence how they feel, approach challenges, and recognize their own strengths.

Through discussion, repetition, movement, and reflection, children practice using encouraging language to celebrate who they are, develop perseverance, and strengthen their belief in themselves.

Learning Objectives

Children will be able to:

- Explain that affirmations are positive and encouraging words we can say to ourselves.
 - Identify words and phrases that support confidence, kindness, and self-belief.
 - Practice using positive self-talk during classroom activities and personal reflection.
 - Recognize that mistakes and challenges are opportunities to learn and grow.
 - Create or share affirmations that reflect their personal strengths, feelings, and qualities.
 - Demonstrate respect and encouragement toward themselves and others.
-

Teacher Script

“Good morning, friends! Does anyone know what an affirmation is?”

Allow time for student responses.

“Affirmations are happy, strong, and loving words we can say to help our hearts feel brave and proud. They remind us that we are important, capable, and special.

When we practice affirmations, we are learning how to speak kindly to ourselves and others. The words we say can help us feel more confident, calm, and ready to try new things.”

Discuss With Students

Talk with students about how words matter.

Explain:

“The words we say to ourselves become part of the way we think and feel. When we practice speaking kindly to ourselves, we help build confidence, courage, gratitude, and self-love.”

Ask:

- Have you ever said something kind to yourself?
 - How do kind words make us feel?
 - How can we use affirmations when something feels hard?
-

Classroom Affirmation Practice

Invite students to repeat affirmations together.

(Teacher points to self first, then gestures toward students.)

Encourage students to say affirmations using:

- Strong voices
- Quiet voices
- Silly voices
- Confident voices
- Motions or hand movements

Sample Affirmations

- I am kind
 - I am loved
 - I can do hard things
 - I am a good friend
 - I am special just the way I am
 - My ideas matter
 - I can keep trying
 - I am brave
 - I am thankful for who I am
 - I am thankful for the things that make me unique
 - My kindness is a gift to others
 - I have special talents that matter
 - I am proud of who I am becoming
 - I can celebrate myself and others
 - Being different makes the world beautiful
 - I am grateful for my heart, mind, and creativity
-

Extension Activity: Mirror Talk

Place a mirror at student eye level.

Invite children to stand in front of the mirror and say affirmations aloud:

- “I am kind.”
- “I am strong.”
- “I am special.”

Encourage students to add their own:

- “I am brave.”
- “I am helpful.”
- “I am a good friend.”

This activity supports self-confidence, self-awareness, and positive self-talk by helping children hear their own encouraging words reflected back to them.

Optional Video Connection

Watch together:

“Positive Affirmations for Kids” (YouTube video)

https://youtu.be/7o_KfrPNwbY

After the video, discuss:

- What did Jessica like about herself?
- What made her special?
- What positive words did she use?
- How did affirmations help her feel?

Week 1 – Friday

What Makes Me Special and Why Am I Grateful for It?

Teacher Reminder

- Allow multiple forms of expression (drawing, writing, dictation, sharing)
- Celebrate effort and participation over accuracy
- Support students who may need help identifying strengths
- Keep the environment safe, encouraging, and affirming
-

Lesson Purpose

This lesson provides children with an opportunity to reflect on their learning from the week and celebrate gratitude, kindness, self-confidence, and belonging. Through classroom reflection, writing, sharing, and community-building activities, children recognize the strengths they bring to their classroom and the important contributions of others.

Children learn that gratitude extends beyond appreciating personal qualities and experiences—it also includes recognizing the people who help make their school and community a caring place.

Learning Objectives

Children will be able to:

- Reflect on personal strengths, accomplishments, and experiences they appreciate.
 - Express gratitude through speaking, drawing, writing, or other forms of communication.
 - Recognize and appreciate the contributions of others in their classroom and school community.
 - Participate in collaborative activities that strengthen classroom belonging.
 - Demonstrate kindness and appreciation through words, actions, and creative expression.
 - Celebrate personal growth and the strengths of classmates.
-

Teacher Script

“Good morning, friends!

This week we have been learning about gratitude, kindness, affirmations, and the special things that make each of us unique.

Today we are going to think about a very important question:

What makes me special, and why am I grateful for it?”

Allow children time to think quietly before responding.

Classroom Community Gratitude and Special Moments Jar

Introduce the classroom jar labeled:

“Our Gratitude and Special Moments Jar”

Throughout the week, students can:

- Write or draw something they are grateful for
- Share something they are proud of about themselves or others

At the end of the week (or every Friday), the class can:

- Pull a few slips from the jar
- Read them aloud
- Celebrate ideas together

This builds anticipation, reflection, and a shared sense of community.

Teacher can add a few slips to pull out and read to the classroom community.

Classroom Writing Activity:

As a class, create a shared gratitude poem on chart paper or butcher paper and display it in the classroom.

Use sentence starters such as:

- I am grateful for...
- I am special because...

- My heart feels happy when...
- I help others by...
- Our classroom is special because...

Write student responses exactly as they are shared whenever possible. This supports ownership, confidence, literacy development, and community building.

*****Poem Example (from the curriculum):**

A printable classroom version is available on the website for teacher use.

Being Grateful

Being grateful is more than saying “thank you.”
It comes from deep in your heart.

You can feel grateful for big things:

- ◆ like your family
- ◆ your home
- ◆ your friends

And small things too:

a hug
a smile
a sunny day

When you are grateful, your heart feels happy,
and you feel proud for all the good things in your life.

Mini-Extension: Community Gratitude: Journal Practice

“Who helps our school every day?”

Guide students in thinking beyond themselves and their classroom to recognize people who support the school community, such as:

- Cafeteria workers
- Custodians
- Crossing guards
- Bus drivers
- Nurses and school support staff

- Office staff and administrators

Discuss how each role helps the school function safely and smoothly.

****Creative Extension

Invite children to:

- Draw thank-you pictures
- Create appreciation cards for school community helpers

These can be delivered, displayed, or shared as a class project (next week or kept in journals as optional work).

Teacher Reflection Script For Friday

“Each of us has special gifts, talents, and qualities that make our classroom better. When we are grateful for who we are and appreciate others for who they are, we create a caring and joyful community.” **Remind children to bring their gratitude bags on Monday. Invite children to share whether they have been practicing gratitude at home. Before they leave, challenge them to tell someone in their family something they love about them and share what makes that person special. Encourage children to listen for how their words make others feel.**

Gratitude Celebration: Family Connection

A Gratitude Celebration letter is sent home to invite families into the learning experience and strengthen the connection between school and home. This celebration gives children the opportunity to share what they have learned about gratitude, kindness, confidence, and what makes them unique and special.

This letter helps families:

- Understand the purpose of the celebration
- Participate in meaningful classroom experiences
- Celebrate their child’s growth and accomplishments
- Support social-emotional learning at home
- Build a stronger sense of classroom and school community

When families are included in children’s learning experiences, students often feel more supported, valued, confident, and connected.

Not all families may be able to attend the Gratitude Celebration, and that is okay. Be mindful to reassure children that every family situation is different and that they are still loved, supported, and celebrated.

Let students know that:

- Pictures and videos may be shared afterward (following school guidelines and permissions)
- Their work and accomplishments are important whether families can attend or not
- The classroom community will celebrate together no matter what

Helping children understand this ahead of time can reduce disappointment and support emotional safety and inclusion for all students and families.

Family Invitation Letter

Dear Families,

Over the past week our classroom community has been exploring gratitude, kindness, self-confidence, and the unique qualities that make each child special. Through stories, discussions, affirmations, movement, art, and reflection, students have been learning how to appreciate themselves, others, and the world around them.

To celebrate their learning, we would like to invite you to our Gratitude Celebration.

During this event, families will have the opportunity to:

- View student projects and gratitude displays
- Participate in family gratitude activities
- Listen to student reflections and affirmations
- Celebrate each child's strengths and contributions
- Reflect on kindness, connection, and self-worth

Our goal is to create a joyful and meaningful experience where every child feels seen, valued, and celebrated.

Don't forget:

“My Gratitude and Special Things Bag” is due on Monday.

Students will collect:

- 3 things they are grateful for

- 3 things that make them special and proud

Items may include:

- Drawings
- Photographs
- Small objects
- Written notes
- Meaningful personal items

Celebration Details:

Date: _____

Time: _____

Location: _____

Thank you for partnering with us in helping children build gratitude, confidence, empathy, and a strong sense of belonging.

Warmly,

[Your Name]

References and Inspiration

- Children's Nebraska
- Early childhood development frameworks
- Positive psychology and gratitude practices
- Research in social-emotional learning (SEL)
- **YouTube. (n.d.). *Affirmations video for children* [Video]. YouTube.**
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7o_KfrPNwbY

Week 2 Gratitude Journey Introduction (Teacher Guidance)

In Week 2, we will begin introducing a few new practices that you will continue to incorporate throughout your gratitude journey with your classroom community.

This week marks an important shift: we are beginning to build daily gratitude habits that become part of our classroom culture, not just a one-time activity.

Our focus is on:

-  Building a strong, positive classroom community
-  Practicing kindness and encouragement toward one another
-  Helping students recognize and value the unique characteristics and strengths they bring to the classroom
-  Creating a space where students build each other up through words and actions

As you move through this week, you will guide students to begin noticing:

- What they appreciate about themselves
- What they appreciate about others
- How their actions and words impact the classroom community

The goal is to help students understand that everyone has something valuable to contribute, and that gratitude helps us see those strengths more clearly.

This week lays the foundation for the rest of your journey—where gratitude becomes a daily habit, kindness becomes intentional, and classroom community becomes deeply connected.

Week 2 activities are designed as simple extensions for:

- circle time
- morning meeting
- large group instruction
- SEL lessons
- transitions
- and classroom community building throughout the week

Week 2 provides opportunities for children to revisit and apply the gratitude, kindness, confidence, and self-awareness skills introduced in Week 1.

Week 2 – Monday: Gratitude in Action

Building Gratitude, Kindness, and Classroom Connection

Lesson Purpose

This lesson helps children understand that gratitude is not only something we feel internally but something we can demonstrate through our words, actions, and relationships with others. Through classroom connection activities, sharing, and reflection, children practice recognizing kindness, appreciating classmates, and understanding how each person contributes to a caring classroom community.

Children learn that gratitude grows when it is shared and that positive words and actions help strengthen friendships, belonging, and connection.

Learning Objectives

Children will be able to:

- Explain how gratitude can be shown through words and actions.
- Recognize and express appreciation for classmates and members of their classroom community.
- Identify ways kindness helps build strong relationships.
- Participate in collaborative activities that promote belonging and connection.
- Share personal experiences and explain why certain objects, memories, or experiences are meaningful.
- Demonstrate respectful listening when others share their ideas and experiences.



Daily Classroom Routine: Morning and Exit Practices

Remind children about the gratitude jar. Have paper readily available so they are able to add to the jar.



Teacher Script

“Good morning, friends!

Last week, we spent time talking about gratitude, kindness, and the things that make each of us special and unique.

We practiced:

- noticing the good things in our lives,

- speaking kindly to ourselves and others,
- learning about what makes us special,
- and showing appreciation for the people around us.

“Today, we are going to continue practicing gratitude by recognizing the kindness, strengths, and positive qualities we see in one another. We are also going to share our Gratitude Bags with our classroom community! I can’t wait to see what you each brought from home. If you were not able to bring a bag, you can still participate by standing up and sharing what you are grateful for and what you would have brought from home.”

Classroom Community Activity

Kindness & Gratitude Compliment Web

Have students sit together in a large circle.

Using a ball of yarn:

1. One student shares:
 - a compliment, or
 - something they are grateful for about another classmate
2. The student then gently tosses the yarn to that child while continuing to hold onto a piece of the yarn.
3. Continue until every child has participated.

As the activity continues, the yarn will create a visible web connecting the entire class.

Discussion Connection

After the web is complete, discuss:

- What do you notice about our web?
- How are we all connected?
- How did it feel to hear kind words from others?
- How does gratitude help build our classroom community?

Explain:

“This web reminds us that kindness, gratitude, and caring words help connect us together. Every person in our classroom matters and helps make our community stronger.”

Gratitude Journal

Prompt:

“What is one thing in your Gratitude and Special Things Bag that you are excited to share with your teacher and friends? Why is it important to you?”

Reminder to Students: Community Gratitude Journal Practice

Teacher: “Friends, remember the special letter you started for our Community Gratitude Journal practice titled *‘Who helps our school every day.’*”

You were working on thinking about all the important people who help our school run smoothly each day. Please continue working on your letter and add more details as you think of new ideas. If you choose to you will deliver your letter to your special person.

Students may:

- draw a picture
- write words or sentences
- label their drawing
- dictate responses to a teacher

Encourage children to think about:

- why the item is meaningful
 - how it connects to gratitude
 - what it says about who they are
 - how it makes them feel (happy, proud, loved, or special)
-

Home Extension Activity Presentation Gratitude and Specials Bag

(During this time, you can take photos to hang on the gratitude board.)

“My Gratitude and Special Things Bag”

Invite students to share items from their Gratitude and Special Things Bag if they feel comfortable.

Students may share:

- 3 things they are grateful for
- 3 things they are proud of about themselves

Items may include:

- drawings
- photographs
- written notes
- favorite objects
- meaningful personal items

Encourage students to explain:

- why the item is important to them
- how it connects to gratitude
- what it says about who they are

Week 2 – Tuesday: Connection Through Kindness



Teacher Reminder

- Encourage participation, but never force sharing.
- Validate all responses equally.
- Model gratitude and connection through your own examples.
- Support students who may need extra time to think before responding.

The goal is to build a classroom culture where every child feels included, valued, and connected through shared gratitude.

Lesson Purpose

This lesson helps children understand that gratitude can strengthen relationships and create a sense of belonging within a classroom community. Through shared conversations, cooperative activities, and acts of appreciation, children recognize that they have experiences, feelings, and relationships that connect them with others.

Children learn that expressing gratitude is a way to show kindness, build friendships, and help others feel valued and appreciated.

Learning Objectives

Children will be able to:

- Identify ways gratitude and kindness can be demonstrated toward others.
- Recognize similarities and shared experiences among classmates.
- Practice active listening and respectful responses during classroom discussions.
- Explain how kind words and actions can positively impact others.
- Reflect on personal choices that contribute to a caring classroom community.
- Express appreciation for individuals who support and help others.



Teacher Script

“Good morning, friends!

We have been learning so much about gratitude, kindness, and what makes each of us special.

Today, we are going to continue practicing gratitude by noticing the kind things we do for others and the things we are thankful for in our classroom community.”



Classroom Community Game

“Me Too!” Gratitude Game

One student shares something they are grateful for.

If other students share the same feeling or experience, they respond:

“Me too!”

Example:

“I’m grateful for my family.” → “Me too!”

Continue with multiple students sharing.

Purpose of the Activity

This activity helps children:

- recognize shared experiences
- build classroom connections
- feel a sense of belonging
- practice listening and responding respectfully
- strengthen empathy and community awareness

Gratitude Jar Reminder and Journal Prompt Choices

Remind students that the Gratitude Jar is available today.

Students may choose to:

- write or draw something they are grateful for with their friends and place it in the jar,
- or
- complete their Gratitude Journal entry.

Let students know that both choices are meaningful ways to reflect and participate.

Journal Prompt

“What is one way you showed kindness or gratitude to someone in your classroom today?”

Students may:

- draw a picture
- write words or sentences
- label their work

- dictate their response to a teacher

Encourage reflection on:

- kindness toward others
 - gratitude in daily actions
 - how their choices impact the classroom community
-

Optional Activity

Special Person Journal Return

Return each student's Special Person Journal from last week.

Let students know:

- sharing is optional
- they may choose to add more to their journal instead

Encourage students to revisit their reflections with pride and confidence.

If possible, take a short walk or field trip around the school to deliver the letters to their special person.

Before delivering the letters, practice with students what they might say when giving their letter. Remind them to speak clearly, make eye contact if they feel comfortable, and use kind words.

Students may say things such as:

- "Thank you for helping our school."
- "I appreciate you."
- "Thank you for being kind to us."
- "Thank you for helping me learn and grow."
- "I am grateful for you."
- "Thank you for taking care of our school."
- "You make our school a better place."

Remind students that even small words of gratitude can make someone feel special, valued, and appreciated.

Week 2 – Wednesday: Celebrating What Makes Us Unique

Tip for Success:

This lesson is meant to be *flexible and ongoing*. Words you can use: Every detail matters, take your time, this is your story.

Reminder:

Give students time to observe themselves, reflect, and choose how they want to express identity (drawing, labeling, speaking, or dictation). There is no single correct way to complete this activity.

Teacher Mindset:

“You are building identity, confidence, and belonging through gratitude.”

Lesson Purpose

This lesson supports children in developing a positive sense of identity by exploring the many qualities that make each person unique. Through reflection, movement, creative expression, and discussion, children recognize that who they are includes their appearance, abilities, interests, feelings, experiences, strengths, and the ways they contribute to others.

Children learn that gratitude includes appreciating themselves and celebrating the unique qualities that make each person valuable and important.

Learning Objectives

Children will be able to:

- Identify personal characteristics, strengths, interests, and qualities that make them unique.
- Recognize that every person’s identity is made up of many different parts.
- Express ideas about themselves through drawing, writing, speaking, or creative representation.
- Demonstrate appreciation and respect for their own identity and the identities of others.
- Practice positive self-expression and confidence when sharing personal ideas.
- Listen respectfully and celebrate classmates’ similarities and differences.

Teacher Script

“Good morning, friends!

Today we are going to start our day by focusing on gratitude and how we use our bodies, our words, and our hearts to show appreciation.

Let’s begin with a morning gratitude stretch together.”

(Pause and guide students through the movements and words. You may also play soft music.)

“Stretch up with me... ‘I’m grateful for a new day!’

Reach out... ‘I’m grateful for my friends!’

Hands on your heart... ‘I’m grateful for me!’

Reach down to your toes... ‘I am grateful for our classroom!’

Bend to one side... ‘I am grateful for...’ (invite students to share their own idea)

Bend to the other side... ‘I am grateful for...’ (invite students to share their own idea)

Beautiful job, friends! Let’s carry that gratitude with us today.”

“Friends, we have been thinking a lot about what makes each of us special and how gratitude helps us notice the good things about ourselves and others. Today, we are going to explore that even more by creating something that shows who you are, what you love, and what makes you unique.”

“You are all important, you all matter, and there is only one you in the whole world. That is something to be grateful for.”

Extension Activity — Life-Size Gratitude & “Special Me” Activity

This activity is not intended to be completed in one sitting. It is a starting point. Students may need additional time to complete their creations, and that is okay.

This activity can be completed in small groups or as a whole group. Have your life-size model or example completed to share with students.

Questions to Pose

Invite students to reflect and share:

- What makes you special?
- What do you notice about yourself when you look in the mirror?
- What color is your hair?
- What color is your skin?
- What color are your eyes?
- Have you lost any teeth yet?
- Do you have any special marks on your skin, like freckles or birthmarks?
- What is something about your appearance that makes you unique?

- What is something about you on the inside that makes you special?

Encourage students to respond in ways that feel comfortable—through speaking, drawing, or sharing with a partner. Allow time for students to look in the mirror as needed.

Student Personalization

Once outlines are complete, students will decorate their “Special Me” figure using:

- drawings
- words
- symbols
- labels
- colors

Encourage students to reflect on who they are and what makes them special.

Sharing and Caring

Allow students time to share their life-size “Special Me” creations with the class or in small groups.

Encourage students to:

- explain what they included
- talk about what makes them special
- share something they are grateful for about themselves
- listen respectfully to classmates

Remind students that:

- everyone’s work is unique
- all responses are important
- we are practicing kindness, listening, and celebration

This is a time to honor each child’s identity and build a caring classroom community through sharing and encouragement.

Week 2 – Thursday: Compliments and Reflection

★ Teacher Reminder

Throughout today’s Compliments and Reflection lesson, the focus is on building a safe, supportive classroom community where students feel comfortable giving and receiving kind words. Keep modeling the language of gratitude and respect consistently.

Lesson Purpose

This lesson helps children understand the power of words and how kindness, appreciation, and encouragement strengthen relationships. Through a Compliment Circle and personal reflection, children practice recognizing positive qualities in others while also developing confidence in their own strengths and accomplishments.

Children learn that gratitude can be expressed through kind words, thoughtful observations, and appreciation for themselves and the people around them.

Learning Objectives

Children will be able to:

- Explain how compliments and kind words can help others feel valued and appreciated.
- Give and receive positive feedback in a respectful classroom environment.
- Identify strengths, talents, and qualities they appreciate about themselves and others.
- Express gratitude through speaking, writing, drawing, or reflection.
- Practice empathy, active listening, and positive communication.
- Recognize that each person contributes valuable qualities to the classroom community.

Teacher Script

“Good morning, friends!

Today we are going to continue our work with gratitude and kindness by focusing on something very important—how we use our words to make others feel seen, valued, and appreciated.

We have been learning that gratitude is not only about what we have or what we receive, but also about the kind things we notice in others and in ourselves.

Today, we are going to practice something called a *Compliment Circle*. A compliment is a kind and positive thing we say about someone else. Compliments help people feel happy, included, and important.

I am going to give someone a compliment first.”

(Provide a compliment to a student.)

“In a few moments, we are going to sit together in a circle and share kind words with one another. You might choose to compliment a friend, thank someone in our classroom, or share something you are proud of about yourself.

Remember, there are no wrong answers. We are practicing kindness, respect, and using our words to build each other up.”

Compliment Circle

Invite everyone to sit together in a classroom circle.

Invite students to:

- compliment a friend
- thank a teacher
- share appreciation for family
- express something they are proud of about themselves

Explain:

“A compliment is something kind we say about someone else. It helps people feel happy, seen, and important.”

Example Sentence Starters

- “I like when ____ plays with me.”
- “I am proud that I keep trying.”
- “My family helps me feel loved.”

Say:

“In our circle today, we are going to:

- share something kind about a friend
- thank someone in our classroom
- or say something we are proud of about ourselves

Remember, there are no wrong answers. We are practicing kindness, gratitude, and using our words to make others feel good.”

“Let’s begin by looking around our circle and noticing all the wonderful people we have in our classroom.”

Social Emotional Learning Focus

This activity supports:

- empathy
 - communication skills
 - gratitude awareness
 - emotional expression
 - positive peer relationships
-

Journal – “What Makes Me Special”

Today’s journal is about *you*, what makes you unique, and what you are grateful for about yourself.

Take a moment to think about all the things that make you *you*. This can include your personality, your talents, your interests, your appearance, and the ways you treat others.

Think about the things that make you proud of yourself and the things you appreciate about who you are becoming.

Journal Prompt

“What makes me special, and what am I grateful for about myself?”

Think About

- What are my strengths?
 - What do I like about my personality?
 - What am I good at?
 - What makes me different from others?
 - What do I appreciate about myself?
 - What makes me proud of who I am?
-

 Family Celebration Reminder

Send a reminder home to families about the Gratitude Celebration tomorrow.

Week 2 – Friday: Celebrate What Makes Us Unique

★ Teacher Reminder – Final Day: Gratitude Celebration

Today is about celebration, connection, and honoring student growth throughout the gratitude unit. The focus is not on perfection or performance, but on joy, reflection, and community.

Keep in mind:

- Prioritize a warm, welcoming atmosphere from the moment families arrive
- Allow students to take ownership as hosts, guides, and participants
- Keep transitions flexible and unhurried so meaningful interactions can happen naturally
- Encourage authentic sharing, but never require public speaking for students who are uncomfortable
- Highlight student voice, effort, and kindness over finished products
- Be present—step back when needed so families and students can connect directly

This is a culmination of the work you have built together. It is a remarkable accomplishment and reflects the intentional efforts you have made to ensure your students feel valued. Small moments of pride, gratitude, and recognition matter more than running every activity perfectly on schedule.

Lesson Purpose

This final lesson provides children with an opportunity to celebrate their learning, reflect on their experiences, and recognize the ways gratitude, kindness, and self-awareness have strengthened their classroom community.

Through movement, reflection, family engagement, and celebration activities, children revisit the important ideas explored throughout the unit: appreciating themselves, recognizing the strengths of others, expressing kindness, and building meaningful connections.

The goal of the Gratitude Celebration is not perfection or performance, but creating a joyful experience where every child feels seen, valued, supported, and celebrated.

Learning Objectives

Children will be able to:

- Reflect on their learning about gratitude, kindness, and self-awareness.
- Identify personal qualities and experiences they appreciate.
- Recognize and celebrate the strengths and contributions of classmates.
- Express gratitude through words, movement, artwork, and reflection.
- Participate in classroom and family activities that strengthen connection and belonging.
- Demonstrate confidence and pride in their personal growth.

Teacher Script

“Good morning, friends! Happy Friday!

Today is a very special day because it is the last day of our gratitude and *‘What Makes Me Special’* unit, and we are going to celebrate all of the wonderful things we have learned together!

Over the past two weeks, we have talked about gratitude, kindness, friendship, feelings, courage, and all of the things that make each of us unique and special. We have practiced using kind words, showing appreciation, helping others, and recognizing the good things in our lives.

I am so proud of each one of you. I have seen you encourage one another, share compliments, listen carefully, show empathy, and grow as a classroom family. Every single one of you brings something important and special to our classroom, and that is something worth celebrating.

Today, we are going to have a Gratitude Celebration! During our celebration, we will reflect on what we learned, celebrate one another, share kind words, and enjoy special activities together. This is a time to remember that gratitude is not something we only practice during this unit—it is something we can carry with us every single day.

Even though today is the last day of our unit, it is not the end of gratitude in our classroom. We will continue practicing gratitude, kindness, and recognizing what makes us special all year long.

Before we begin our celebration, I want you to think about this question:

‘What is one thing you are grateful for today, and what is one thing that makes YOU special?’

Now stand up, and we are going to have a dance break!”

Gratitude Dance Break

Begin by playing music for students. Explain that when the music starts, they should move around the space freely. When the music stops, everyone should immediately freeze and share something they are grateful for.

In the next round, when the music pauses, students will share something that makes them special or unique.

In a final round, when the music stops again, students will identify and share something they appreciate about a friend. (others: family, pets etc.)

When the music stops, students pause and share something they are grateful for before continuing.

This routine supports:

- emotional regulation
 - joy and movement
 - reflection through play
 - gratitude awareness
-

OPTIONAL Gratitude Celebration Ideas:

Opening Celebration Message

Today



Gratitude Celebration

Welcome Activity

As families arrive:

- Students greet families at the door
- Play calm or joyful music
- Display classroom work and projects

Showcase:

- o Gratitude Wall
 - o Gratitude Jar
 - o Affirmation work
 - o Student art and writing
 - o Any and all other work you have created
-



Affirmation Mirror Stations

Place mirrors around the room with affirmations such as:

- “I am important.”
 - “I am kind.”
 - “I matter.”
 - “The world is better because of me.”
-



Gratitude Gallery Walk

Families walk through the classroom to view:

- Student artwork
- Gratitude writing

- “What Makes Me Special” projects
- Class poems
- Photos of classroom activities

Students may act as tour guides to explain their learning.

Family Gratitude Circle Activity

Families sit together and complete sentence starters:

- I am grateful for...
- One thing I love about my child is...
- Our family is special because...
- One thing my child teaches me is...

These reflections may be displayed or sent home as keepsakes.

Gratitude Jar Ceremony

Read selected gratitude notes from the classroom jar.

This allows children and families to hear:

- Appreciation for classmates
 - Positive reflections
 - Empathy-building statements
 - Joyful classroom moments
-

“You Matter” Teacher Moments

Give each child a personalized note from the teacher. This can be handed out and recognized in front of families if you choose.

Examples:

- “Your kindness makes our classroom brighter.”
- “I love how creative you are.”
- “You help others feel included.”
- “Your smile makes people happy.”

These notes often become meaningful keepsakes for families.

Closing Celebration Message

“Our classroom is special because every child in this community matters. When we practice gratitude, kindness, and confidence, we help make the world a brighter place.”

Thank you for allowing me to learn, grow, laugh, and celebrate alongside each of your children during this gratitude journey. I am so proud of the kindness, courage, and love your students have shown one another. Friends, remember: you are special, you are important, and you each have something wonderful to share with the world.”

Optional Take-Home Gifts

- Affirmation bracelets
 - Gratitude journals
 - Kindness certificates
 - Family gratitude cards
 - Small mirrors with affirmations
 - Personalized notes from you to each child sharing what you are thankful for about them and what makes them special
-

Teacher Reflection for the unit.

Children build their self-concept through daily interactions and experiences. The language used by adults becomes part of their inner voice.

When children consistently hear:

- “I’m proud of you.”
- “You are important.”
- “I’m happy you are here.”
- “You worked so hard.”

they begin to believe those messages about themselves.

Gratitude practices are not about perfection or forced positivity. They are about helping children notice joy, recognize strengths, build empathy, and understand that they matter in this world.

Teacher Reflection Question

How might you adapt or expand this curriculum the next time you use it?

Dear Teacher/Family,
I am so proud of you!

Thank you for the incredible work you have done throughout this unit. Your engagement, support, and commitment have helped create meaningful learning experiences centered around gratitude, kindness, and community.

This unit is more than a series of activities—it is an intentional effort to nurture Social-Emotional Learning (SEL) and help each child recognize their own uniqueness, strengths, and value within the classroom community. Your participation has played an important role in helping students feel seen, supported, and celebrated.

We encourage you to continue weaving kindness, reflection, and SEL conversations into your daily routines beyond this unit. These practices build lasting habits that support both academic and personal growth.

Additional materials, resources, and extensions are available on the website. Please continue to scroll to find aligned Math standards and other supporting content.

Thank you again for your dedication and for partnering in this meaningful learning journey.

Dr. Tisha Shipley



About the Author



Dr. Tisha Shipley is an early childhood educator, professor, author, blogger, curriculum developer, presenter, and podcaster with more than 25 years of experience working with young children, educators, and families. Throughout her career, she has served as a Pre-K and kindergarten teacher, gifted and talented educator, elementary summer school principal, university professor, mentor, faculty leader, and cheer sponsor. Her work focuses on developmentally appropriate practice, social-emotional learning, student engagement, curriculum development, and creating caring, inclusive learning environments where every child can recognize and celebrate their strengths.

Dr. Shipley holds a bachelor's and master's degree from Northwestern Oklahoma State University and a doctorate in Curriculum and Instruction. Her doctoral research, *Giving Teachers a Voice: Lived Experiences Implementing Developmentally Appropriate Practice*, reflects her commitment to honoring how young children learn and supporting educators in their work. As a presenter, she shares practical strategies through professional development, conferences, workshops, and educational events.

Dr. Shipley is the author and creator of *Rider's Magic Mark* and its companion curriculum, *Being Grateful for What Makes You Special: Caring Classroom Philosophy*. She is also the co-host of *Early Childhood Chatter* and *unEDited Chatter*, where she and her co-host explore education, teaching, leadership, and the real experiences behind the work of educators.

Dr. Shipley believes every child deserves to feel seen, valued, connected, and empowered to recognize the strengths that make them unique.



Curriculum Alignment & Educational Framework Connections

Being Grateful for What Makes You Special: A Caring Classroom Philosophy

This curriculum integrates children’s literature, social-emotional learning, reflective practices, classroom community building, and family connections to support children’s development of gratitude, confidence, kindness, empathy, and a positive sense of identity.

The curriculum is intentionally aligned with nationally recognized early childhood frameworks, including the **National Association for the Education of Young Children (NAEYC) Developmentally Appropriate Practice** framework, the **Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning (CASEL) framework**, and early childhood developmental learning outcomes appropriate for **Pre-Kindergarten through Grade 2**.

NAEYC Developmentally Appropriate Practice (DAP) Alignment

Creating Caring and Responsive Relationships

This curriculum supports strong teacher-child and peer relationships by:

- Creating a classroom environment where children feel seen, valued, respected, and included.
- Encouraging meaningful conversations about identity, emotions, strengths, and experiences.
- Building a sense of belonging through gratitude practices, classroom routines, and community activities.

- Supporting children’s emotional safety through choice, encouragement, and respectful interactions.

Examples within the curriculum:

- Morning welcome and exit routines
 - Gratitude Wall
 - Compliment Circle
 - Gratitude Celebration
-

Supporting Social-Emotional Development

This curriculum supports children’s growing understanding of themselves and others by helping children:

- Recognize personal strengths, talents, and unique qualities.
- Develop confidence and positive self-concept.
- Express feelings and ideas through discussion, reflection, writing, and creative expression.
- Practice kindness, empathy, appreciation, and respectful communication.

Examples within the curriculum:

- “What Makes Me Special” activities
 - Affirmations
 - Gratitude Journals
 - Reflection activities
-

Intentional Teaching Practices

Teachers are supported in using intentional strategies including:

- Open-ended questioning
- Teacher modeling
- Guided conversations
- Reflection opportunities

- Hands-on and interactive experiences
- Individualized support for children’s different ways of participating

The curriculum recognizes that children learn through active engagement, relationships, exploration, and meaningful experiences.

Equity, Inclusion, and Belonging

This curriculum promotes an inclusive classroom community by:

- Celebrating children’s individual identities, strengths, cultures, experiences, and differences.
 - Encouraging children to appreciate both visible and invisible qualities that make each person unique.
 - Providing multiple ways for children to participate and express themselves.
 - Recognizing that every child and family has valuable experiences to contribute.
-

CASEL Social and Emotional Learning (SEL) Alignment

Self-Awareness

Children develop the ability to:

- Identify emotions, strengths, talents, interests, and personal qualities.
- Recognize what makes them unique and valuable.
- Develop confidence and a positive sense of self.

Curriculum Connections:

- Special Me activities
 - Gratitude Journals
 - Affirmations
 - Self-reflection prompts
-

Self-Management

Children develop skills to:

- Practice positive self-talk.
- Build confidence when approaching challenges.
- Reflect on feelings and experiences.
- Develop habits of gratitude and mindfulness.

Curriculum Connections:

- Morning gratitude routines
 - Affirmation practice
 - Reflection activities
-

Social Awareness

Children develop the ability to:

- Recognize and appreciate the strengths and experiences of others.
- Understand that people may have similarities and differences.
- Show empathy and appreciation for members of their classroom and school community.

Curriculum Connections:

- Compliment Circle
 - Gratitude Web
 - School Community Appreciation activities
-

Relationship Skills

Children practice:

- Communicating respectfully.
- Listening to others.
- Giving and receiving compliments.
- Building positive relationships with peers and adults.

Curriculum Connections:

- Classroom community activities

- Sharing circles
 - Family celebration activities
-

Responsible Decision-Making

Children learn to:

- Recognize how their words and actions affect others.
- Make choices that support kindness, respect, and inclusion.
- Contribute positively to their classroom community.

Curriculum Connections:

- Kindness reflections
 - Gratitude actions
 - Community-building activities
-

Early Childhood Learning Outcomes Alignment

Pre-Kindergarten–Grade 2

This curriculum supports development across multiple areas of early learning:

Social-Emotional Development

Children will:

- Develop positive self-identity and confidence.
 - Recognize personal strengths and abilities.
 - Build friendships and positive relationships.
 - Practice empathy, kindness, and appreciation.
-

Language and Communication

Children will:

- Participate in meaningful conversations.

- Express thoughts, feelings, and experiences.
 - Listen and respond respectfully to others.
 - Build vocabulary related to emotions, gratitude, kindness, and identity.
-

Approaches to Learning

Children will:

- Engage in reflection and problem-solving.
 - Demonstrate curiosity about themselves and others.
 - Build confidence in sharing ideas.
 - Develop perseverance and positive thinking.
-

Creativity and Expression

Children will:

- Communicate ideas through art, writing, movement, and storytelling.
 - Represent personal experiences and strengths creatively.
 - Use multiple forms of expression to share learning.
-

Family and Community Connections

Children will:

- Recognize the important people who support them.
- Strengthen connections between home and school.
- Participate in meaningful family engagement opportunities.

Appendix: Curriculum Alignment at a Glance

Being Grateful for What Makes You Special: A Caring Classroom Philosophy

Lesson	NAEYC Alignment	CASEL SEL Alignment	Developmental Outcomes
Week 1 Monday What Does It Mean to Be Grateful?	• Builds relationships and classroom community • Encourages student voice • Supports emotional development	Self-Awareness Recognizing gratitude and appreciation Social Awareness Recognizing positive relationships	• Emotional awareness • Language development • Sense of belonging
Week 1 Tuesday What Makes You Special and Unique?	• Supports identity development • Promotes inclusion and appreciation of differences • Encourages respectful discussion	Self-Awareness Recognizing strengths and qualities Social Awareness Respecting differences	• Positive self-identity • Communication skills • Appreciation of others
Week 1 Wednesday Celebrating What Makes Me Special	• Supports individual expression • Encourages child-centered learning • Strengthens family connections	Self-Awareness Understanding personal strengths Relationship Skills Sharing experiences	• Self-expression • Reflection • Confidence building
Week 1 Thursday Affirmations: Speaking Kind Words to Ourselves	• Creates emotional safety • Supports confidence • Uses intentional teaching practices	Self-Awareness Recognizing positive qualities Self-Management Positive self-talk	• Emotional regulation • Self-confidence • Positive learning behaviors
Week 1 Friday Celebrating Gratitude, Strengths, and Community	• Builds classroom community • Encourages collaboration • Supports family connections	Social Awareness Appreciating others Relationship Skills Building connections	• Collaboration • Communication • Social interaction

Week 2 Monday
Gratitude in Action

- Supports relationships and belonging
- Encourages cooperative learning
- Connects home and school

Social Awareness
Recognizing kindness

Relationship Skills
Building friendships

- Empathy
- Listening skills
- Cooperation

Week 2 Tuesday
Recognizing Kindness and Appreciation

- Promotes respectful communication
- Strengthens peer relationships
- Recognizes community members

Social Awareness
Understanding others

Relationship Skills
Expressing appreciation

- Communication
- Community awareness
- Social skills

Week 2 Wednesday
Special Me: Celebrating My Identity

- Supports identity and belonging
- Celebrates diversity
- Encourages multiple forms of expression

Self-Awareness
Understanding identity and strengths

Social Awareness
Respecting uniqueness

- Self-concept
- Creativity
- Personal expression

Week 2 Thursday
Compliments and Reflection

- Supports positive relationships
- Creates emotionally safe interactions
- Builds classroom community

Relationship Skills
Giving and receiving kindness

Self-Awareness
Recognizing strengths

- Empathy
- Communication
- Confidence

Week 2 Friday
Gratitude Celebration

- Strengthens family partnerships
- Honors student voice
- Celebrates growth and belonging

Self-Awareness
Reflecting on growth

Social Awareness
Celebrating others

Relationship Skills
Connecting with community

- Reflection
- Collaboration
- Family engagement

Overall Framework Alignment

Framework

Alignment Focus

NAEYC Developmentally Appropriate Practice

Relationships, belonging, intentional teaching, equity, inclusion, and family partnerships

Framework**Alignment Focus****CASEL Social and Emotional Learning Framework**

Self-awareness, self-management, social awareness, relationship skills, and responsible decision-making

Pre-Kindergarten–Grade 2 Developmental Outcomes

Identity development, communication, emotional awareness, creativity, collaboration, and problem-solving

Educator Note:

This alignment serves as a guide for educators and may be adapted to meet individual state, district, school, or program requirements.

*****This curriculum includes alignment to the National Association for the Education of Young Children (NAEYC) and the Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning (CASEL). Because professional standards and frameworks may be revised over time, educators are encouraged to review the most current versions of these frameworks to ensure continued alignment with current guidance.

Cross-Curricular Connections

Being Grateful for What Makes You Special: A Caring Classroom Philosophy

Learning Area	Connection to Curriculum	Examples from Lessons
English Language Arts / Literacy	Children develop communication skills through discussions, storytelling, journaling, vocabulary development, and expressing ideas through speaking, drawing, and writing.	• Read-aloud: <i>Rider's Magic Mark</i> • Gratitude Journals • Class Gratitude Poem • Reflection Questions • Family Letters • “Who Helps Our School Every Day?” activity
Social Studies / Civics	Children explore identity, relationships, classroom community, appreciation of others, and the ways people contribute to a community.	• Appreciation letters to school helpers • Classroom community activities • Learning about similarities and differences
Health Education / Wellness	Children develop emotional awareness, self-care practices, positive self-talk, confidence, and healthy relationship skills.	• Affirmations • Gratitude practices • Emotional reflection • Compliment Circle
Art / Creative Expression	Children communicate identity, feelings, ideas, and experiences through creative representation.	• “Special Me” life-size project • Student artwork • Gratitude Wall • Classroom displays

Learning Area	Connection to Curriculum	Examples from Lessons
Speaking and Listening Skills	Children practice sharing ideas, listening to others, taking turns, and communicating respectfully.	• Circle discussions • Partner conversations • Gratitude Celebration sharing
Technology Integration (Optional)	Children may use technology to document learning, share reflections, or access supplemental resources when developmentally appropriate.	• Digital gratitude displays • Classroom photos (following school policies) • Optional video connections

Math Skill	Possible Connection
Counting and Data Collection	Students count gratitude notes in the Gratitude Jar, survey classroom favorites, or create simple graphs about classroom interests.
Sorting and Classification	Students sort gratitude ideas into categories such as people, places, experiences, and things.
Patterns	Students create patterns using affirmation cards, kindness bracelets, or classroom displays.

Growing Gratitude and Confidence

A Caring Classroom Curriculum

A Two-Week Journey of Gratitude, Confidence, Kindness, and Community



Pre-K–Grade 3 | Social-Emotional Learning | Teacher & Student Activities